

Behavioural interviews

What this round is and how it runs

A behavioural question asks what you **did**, not what you **would do**. The idea is simple: how you handled a real disagreement last year tells an interviewer more than any promise about the future. In the 2026 placement reports that ISB students wrote up, 285 of 585 interview rounds were behavioural, HR or resume rounds (Figure F.1). The single most common thing interviewers did was pick a line from the resume and keep asking “why?” and “how?” until the story either held or fell apart.

Behavioural, HR or resume rounds that touched each theme (285 such rounds, 57 companies; one round can touch several)

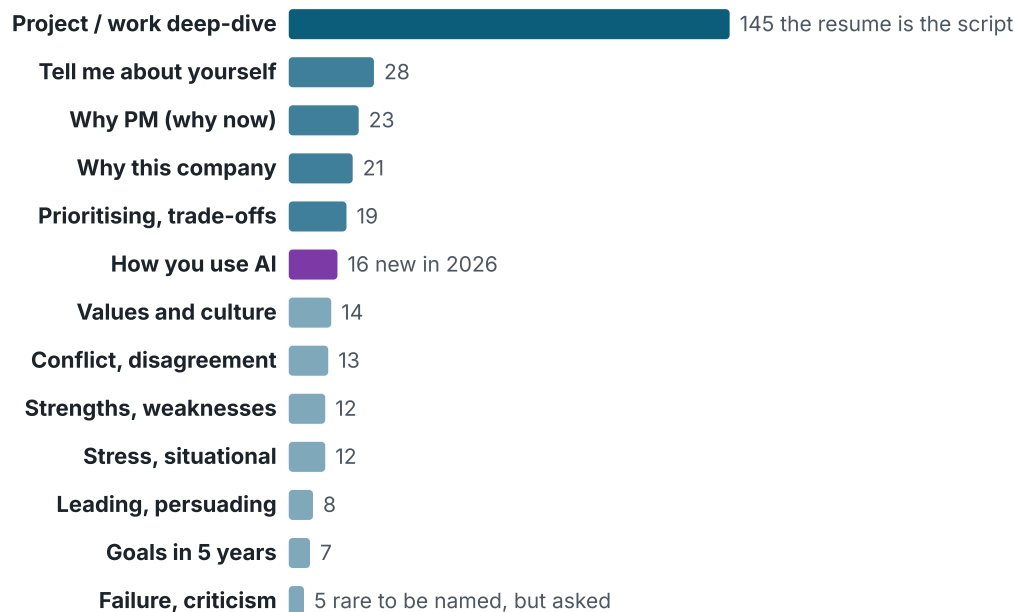


Figure F.1 • What PM interviewers actually asked in 2026. Deep-dives into your own projects outnumber every other theme put together. Failure is rarely named in the reports, but it is the story most people haven't prepared. *Author's count of 585 rounds reported by ISB students, BTC Handbook 2026, pp. 69–177 (keyword match per round; many reports only say “some behavioural questions”, so these are lower bounds).*

A round rarely follows a script. It usually opens with “tell me about yourself”, moves to one project on your resume, then drills: *why that way? what did you do yourself? what was the number? what went wrong?* Somewhere in the middle come “why PM” and “why us”. It can jump to a product question at any point: one candidate named Google Maps as their favourite product and was then asked to build a Maps feature for a specific group of users. So don't prepare separate answers for separate rounds. Prepare a handful of true stories deeply, and you'll be ready wherever the conversation goes.

What the interviewer is scoring

Behind the friendly chat, most interviewers fill in a short scorecard. The five things on it are the same almost everywhere (Figure F.2). Each one has an easy good sign and an easy red flag. Most candidates who fail this round are not bad people with bad stories. They are people who said “we” for three minutes, gave no number, or offered a weakness that was a boast in disguise.

Ownership	Judgement	Working with people	Self-awareness	Motivation
Good sign "I decided...", "I built..." clear about your part	Good sign why this option and not the other one	Good sign names the other side's view fairly	Good sign a real mistake and what changed after	Good sign a real moment that led here; knows us
Red flag only "we"; can't say what you did yourself	Red flag "it just made sense"; no alternatives named	Red flag blames others; "they didn't get it"	Red flag a fake weakness; "I work too hard"	Red flag a template line that fits any company

Figure F.2 · Five things on the scorecard. Every question in this round is a way to read one or two of these. "Tell me about a failure" reads self-awareness; "why us" reads motivation; a project deep-dive reads ownership and judgement at once. *Author's summary, drawn from the ISB handbook's notes on this round (pp. 39–43) and the 2026 reports.*

KEY IDEA · YOUR RESUME IS THE QUESTION PAPER

Half the round is built from what you wrote. Mastercard's round was described as "detailed grilling on each and every point of the resume". Before any interview, read your resume line by line and ask yourself: could I talk about this for two minutes, give a number, and say what I'd do differently? If not, fix the line or learn the story behind it.

BEHAVIOURAL INTERVIEWS · STORY BANK

Build a story bank

You can't make up a good story on the spot, under pressure, in two minutes. So build a small bank before the interviews: six true stories, each known well enough that you can tell it from any angle. One story about a messy project can answer a conflict question, a prioritising question or a failure question, depending on which part you tell.

Where stories come from, whatever your background

Background	Good places to look	Example of a usable story
Fresher	college fest or committee, sports team, group project, internship, a small business at home	Ran sponsorship for a fest with a ₹4 lakh target and lost a big sponsor two weeks out
Engineer or analyst	a feature you shipped, an outage, a dashboard people used or ignored, a data finding that changed a plan	Built a claims-status page that cut "where is my claim?" calls
Business role	sales targets, a new region, an operations fix, a client escalation, a vendor negotiation	Convinced 30 depot managers to use a new stock tracker
Career switcher	the moment you noticed users, a side project, a process you redesigned, the reason you left	A teacher who built a WhatsApp quiz routine used by 200 students

The six stories that cover almost everything

The ISB handbook found that nearly every "tell me about a time" question its students faced collapsed into a few underlying stories. For PM rounds, six are enough:

1. **A project you drove from start to finish** (for deep-dives, "most proud of", execution).
2. **A disagreement** with a manager, a teammate or another team (for conflict, working with people).
3. **A real setback or failure**, with what you changed afterwards (for failure, criticism, weakness).
4. **A time you persuaded people who didn't report to you** (for leadership, influence).
5. **A hard trade-off or a "no"** (for prioritising, saying no, short term vs long term).
6. **A time data or a user changed your mind** (for judgement, being wrong, curiosity).

The story card: bullets, not a script

Write each story as short bullet memories, never as a paragraph to learn by heart. A memorised speech breaks the moment the interviewer interrupts, and good interviewers interrupt on purpose. Bullets let you start anywhere. Here is one card, filled in, for the stock-tracker story (Figure F.3).

Context and stakes	FMCG firm, 30 depots in Maharashtra. Stock-outs of fast sellers every month-end; about ₹40 lakh of lost sales a quarter.
My role	Supply-chain analyst, 2 years in. Nobody asked me to fix it; I owned the tracker from idea to roll-out.
Key decisions and why	Built it in Google Sheets, not the ERP, so depots could use it in a week, not six months. Tracked only 40 fast-moving items, not all 600.
What I did myself	Visited 6 depots; watched how managers counted stock; built the sheet; ran a 2-depot pilot; wrote a one-page guide in Marathi and English.
Stakeholders	Depot managers (sceptical: "one more report"); my manager (worried about data errors); the regional head (wanted it everywhere fast).
Result	28 of 30 depots using it in 8 weeks. Month-end stock-outs down from about 14% of fast sellers to 6%.
Reflection	I launched it without asking depot managers what they'd stop doing, so two depots dropped it. Now I remove one old task for every new one I add.

Figure F.3 · One story card, filled. Seven short rows. The same card answers "a project you're proud of" (tell the result), "influence without authority" (tell the stakeholders), and "a mistake" (tell the reflection). *Card layout adapted from the ISB handbook (p. 43); the story is illustrative, written for this guide.*

One story, many questions

Your six stories →	Project	Disagreement	Setback	Persuasion	Trade-off	Changed my mind
Walk me through a project	●			○	○	
Conflict with a manager or teammate		●		○		
A failure, or a time you were criticised	○		●			○
Strengths and weaknesses	○		●			
Leading or persuading without authority	○			●		
Prioritising, saying no		○			●	
A decision with little information					○	●
Why PM	●					○

● best fit · ○ also works, if you tell a different part of the story. If one story is ticking more than three rows, you are leaning on it too much: an interviewer who hears the same project twice will notice.

BEHAVIOURAL INTERVIEWS · FRAMEWORK

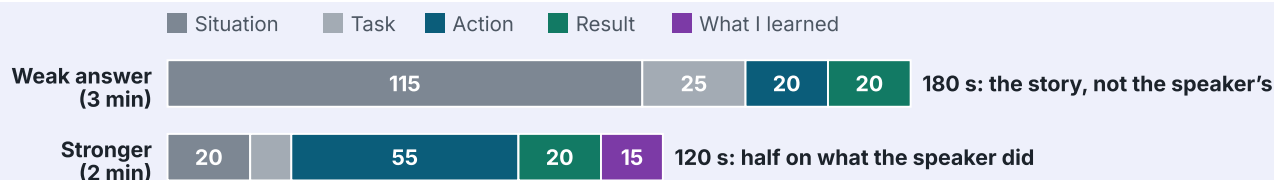
FRAMEWORK · STAR, USED LOOSELY

1 The situation that needs it. A typical weak answer to "tell me about a time you failed": three minutes on a college fest where "the team" missed a sponsor deadline, one line about the speaker, and "but it all worked out". The interviewer learns a lot about the fest and nothing about the candidate.

2 An everyday example. You come home at 1 a.m. and your parents are waiting up. They don't want the full story of the party. They want three things: what happened, what you did about it, and whether it will happen again. If you spend ten minutes on who was at the party, you're in trouble.

3 The framework. STAR stands for **Situation** (the background, briefly), **Task** (what you had to get done), **Action** (what you did, and why) and **Result** (what changed, with a number if you have one). PM interviewers almost always add a fifth part: what you learned or would do differently. The key is the time split. About half of a two-minute answer should be Action, because that is the only part that shows *you* (Figure F.4).

Coming home late	A behavioural answer
"There was a party at Rohan's." (one line)	Situation: "Our fest lost its main sponsor two weeks out."
"I had to get home by 11."	Task: "I owned the ₹4 lakh sponsorship target."
"The last metro was cancelled, so I called Papa, then shared a cab with two friends."	Action: what you did, step by step, and why you chose it.
"I got home at 1."	Result: "We raised ₹3.4 lakh, 85% of the target."
"Next time I'll check the metro timings before I go."	What I learned: the change you made afterwards.



Bars are seconds (illustrative). The interviewer can only score what you did, so give that part half the time.

Figure F.4 · Where the two minutes go. The weak answer spends most of its time on background. The stronger one tells the background in 20 seconds and spends a minute on what the speaker did. *Author's illustration.*

Using it, step by step

1. Start with one sentence of context and one of your task. If you need a third, cut something.
2. Tell your actions in order, using "I". For each important one, add the reason: "I did X because Y."
3. Give the result as a number ("stock-outs from 14% to 6%") or, if you have no number, a clear direction ("complaints stopped").
4. End with one line on what you'd change or now do differently. Then stop talking.

COMMON SLIP Using "we" all through the action. Saying "we" for the team's result is fine. For the actions, say which part was yours.

4 When it misleads. STAR is a checklist for **preparing** a story, not a script for telling it. The ISB handbook warns that forcing every answer through four boxes sounds rehearsed. A candidate who says "The situation was... the task was..." out loud sounds like they're reading a form. And interviewers will interrupt after the situation to ask "why?", which breaks a memorised run. Like a recipe you know well, you don't read out the steps; you just cook.

5 In the interview. Don't announce the boxes. Say something like: "Short version of the background, then what I did, then how it turned out: ..." and go.

BEHAVIOURAL INTERVIEWS · THE QUESTIONS

The questions, most asked first

Each question starts with how it was actually put in 2026 PM interviews, taken from ISB students' reports. Where a candidate wrote down what they actually said and how the interviewer reacted, that is shown in a "From a real interview" box, in summary. The worked answer after it is **written for this guide** and labelled so: the reports record questions, not full answers. The follow-up questions inside each answer are the kinds the reports show interviewers really asking.

QUESTION 1 · WALK ME THROUGH A PROJECT

Asked in 145 of 285 rounds

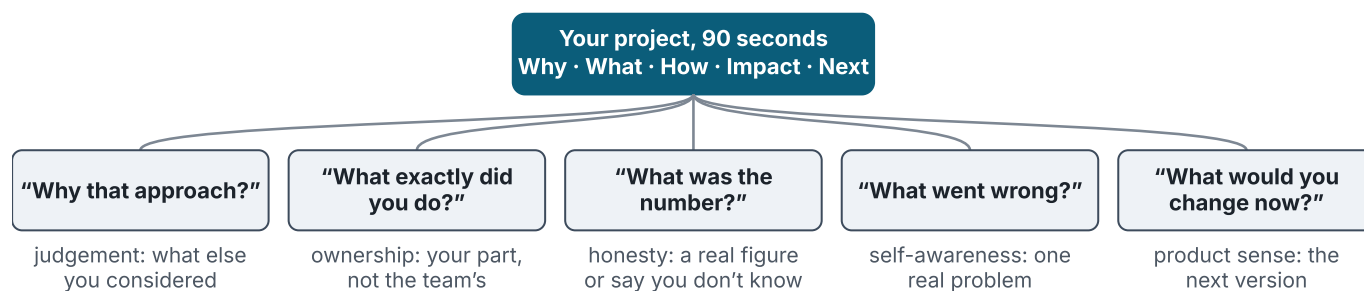
AS ACTUALLY ASKED "Detailed deep-dive into a project where you showcased that skill-set ... What component were you responsible for?" (Sirion) · "Tell me about the most complex project you have worked on, why it was that complex, and what you did to handle that" (Ethos) · "What would you want to change about it if you were to go back?" (Salesforce)

What they're checking. Whether you did what your resume says, whether you understood why, and whether you can think about your own work like a product. The first answer matters less than the third follow-up. Prepare every line on your resume with five parts (Figure F.5): why it was needed, what you did, how you chose to do it, the impact, and what you'd do next.

FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · PRACTO, 2026 (CO-FOUNDER ROUND)

The candidate described a user-acquisition project. The co-founder asked straight away: "What was the CAC?" (customer acquisition cost: what it cost to win one user). The candidate didn't remember the exact figure and chose not to guess, because the interviewer could easily have shown a made-up number didn't add up. Instead they said they didn't recall the exact number, but they knew it was too high to keep going, and that was why the team shut that channel down. The interviewer accepted this and moved to a spreadsheet problem on costs and break-even, to check the candidate was comfortable with numbers. The candidate listed that honesty as one of the things that "worked in favour".

Source: ISB BTC Handbook 2026, interview reports, pp. 107–108. Summarised.



Every branch can go two or three levels deeper. A line you can't defend for two minutes should come off the resume.

Figure F.5 · How a deep-dive branches. A 90-second telling, then the five follow-ups interviewers use most. Each one tests a different item on the scorecard. *Structure from the ISB handbook (p. 41); follow-ups from the 2026 reports.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · analyst at a general insurer, 2 years

- Q** Walk me through the claims-status project on your resume.
- A** Customers who filed a motor claim had no way to see where it stood, so they called us. About 9,000 “where is my claim?” calls a month, roughly a third of all our calls. I was the analyst on the claims team. I proposed a simple status page with SMS updates and owned it from the idea to the launch, working with two developers.
- Q** What exactly did you do yourself?
- A** Three things. I pulled six months of call logs and found that 70% of these calls came in the two days after the surveyor’s visit, when nothing visible happened. I turned our 14 internal claim stages into 5 that a customer understands. And I wrote the SMS that goes out whenever a claim moves to the next stage.
- Why this move: “three things” with a number each makes the answer about the speaker. The call-log finding shows the idea came from evidence.*
- Q** Why five stages and not fourteen?
- A** Customers don’t care about “pending level-2 approval”. They want to know if someone is working on it and when the money comes. Fewer stages also meant fewer confusing messages when a claim went back a step internally. The cost was that agents lost detail, so we kept all 14 stages on their screen.
- Q** And the result?
- A** Status calls fell from about 9,000 to 7,400 a month within a quarter, about 18% down. I had hoped for 30%. When I read the remaining calls, half were about *how much* would be paid, not the stage. If I went back, I’d show the approved amount and the expected payout date. That’s the question behind the question.
- Why this move: admitting the miss, and knowing why, is the strongest part of the answer. Interviewers keep asking “what would you change?” because it shows whether you think like a PM about your own work.*

Weak line

“We built a dashboard that really improved efficiency across the team.”

Better line

“I built the status page; ‘where is my claim’ calls fell about 18% in a quarter, short of my 30% goal, and here’s why.”

If you don’t know the number: say so, and give the direction and what you did about it, as the Practo candidate did. A guessed number that falls apart under one follow-up costs more than an honest “I don’t remember exactly”.

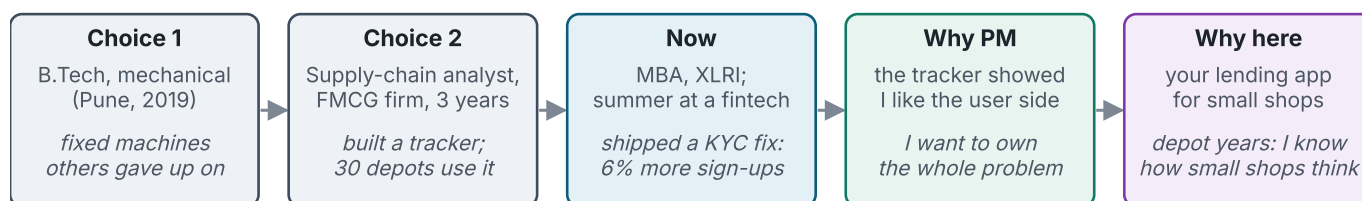
QUESTION 2 · TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF

28 rounds, usually the opener

AS ACTUALLY ASKED “Walk me through the work you have done, in one line for each role” (Sirion) · “Tell me about yourself. Why do you want to be a product manager? Why do you want to join us?” (2026 report, p. 161)

What they’re checking. Whether your choices make sense together, and whether you can be clear in 90 seconds. Don’t recite the resume in date order; they have it in front of them. Explain the **choices** behind it and the thread that joins them, then land on why this role (Figure F.6).

The thread tying it together: "I keep building small tools that people with messy jobs actually use."



Grey = the past, told as choices with a reason. Blue = today. Green and purple = where you're going and why this company fits. About 20 seconds a box: 90 to 120 seconds in all. Example is illustrative.

Figure F.6 · A "tell me about yourself" as five boxes. Past choices with a reason, one result as proof, then why PM and why this company. The thread on top is the one line you want them to remember. *Author's illustration; career-switcher example written for this guide.*

FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · PRACTO, 2026

One candidate described planting "2–3 curiosity cues" in their introduction: small details that make the interviewer want to ask more, so the next question is on ground the candidate knows well. They also looked up the interviewer on LinkedIn beforehand, which gave them common points to talk about from the start, and reworded their introduction to match the company's mission and the role. *ISB BTC Handbook 2026, p. 107. Summarised.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · career switcher: mechanical engineer → supply chain → MBA

A I'm Arjun. I studied mechanical engineering in Pune because I liked fixing machines that others had given up on. I joined an FMCG company as a supply-chain analyst, and spent three years in depots in Maharashtra. The work I enjoyed most was building a simple stock tracker that 28 of our 30 depots ended up using. It cut month-end stock-outs by more than half. That's when I noticed the part I liked wasn't the spreadsheet. It was watching how depot managers really worked and making something they'd actually use. That's why I came to XLRI, and why I spent my summer at a fintech, where I shipped a small fix to the KYC flow that lifted sign-ups by about 6%. I want to be a PM because I want to own the whole problem, not one piece of it. And your lending app for small shops fits, because I've spent three years seeing how small businesses think about stock and cash.

Q You said depot managers "really worked" a certain way. What did you see?

Why this move: the depot detail was a curiosity cue. The interviewer picked it up, so the next five minutes are on the candidate's strongest story.

Weak opening

"I did my B.Tech in 2019, then I joined XYZ as an analyst, where my responsibilities included..."

Better opening

"I studied mechanical because I liked fixing machines others gave up on. That habit is the thread through everything since."

QUESTION 3 · WHY PRODUCT MANAGEMENT? WHY NOW?

23 rounds

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "Why PM? Why now? ... What is PM in one word?" (HiLabs) · "why product after such deeply technical SDE roles" (Razorpay) · "Why PM and not coding?" (Microsoft)

What they're checking. Whether you know what the job is really like, and whether you want it for a real reason. The weak answer is a template: "I love solving problems and working across teams." Every candidate that season says it. The strong answer names a real moment when you did PM-like work, what you liked about it, and what you still need to learn.



FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · HILABS, 2026

After "Why PM? Why now?", one interviewer asked candidates to describe PM in one word. According to the report, he was listening for "prioritisation". The candidate felt the round was "more of a personality test". The lesson: have a short, honest view of what the job is mostly about, in your own words. Choosing what *not* to build is a good one. *ISB BTC Handbook 2026, p. 83. Summarised.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · software engineer, 2 years at a payments company

A In my second year as an engineer, our refund API was failing for about 2% of requests. I fixed the bug in a day. But I kept reading the support tickets, and saw that the bigger problem was that merchants couldn't tell whether a refund had gone through. I wrote a one-page note proposing a refund-status webhook, got my manager to take it to the product team, and it shipped a quarter later. Tickets on refunds fell by about a third. Fixing the bug was satisfying. Deciding what the merchant actually needed was the part I couldn't stop thinking about.

Q Why not stay an engineer and do that on the side?

A I did, for a year, and it only worked because a PM made room for my note. I want to be the person who decides what gets built and answers for it. My engineering background helps with trade-offs. What I still need is practice with users outside payments and with saying no, which is why I did my summer on a consumer app.

Why this move: naming a gap (saying no, non-payments users) shows you know what the job is. The "why now" is answered by the summer project, not by a slogan.

Template

"PM sits at the intersection of business, tech and design, and I love all three."

Real

"I fixed the bug in a day, but kept reading the tickets. Deciding what the merchant needed was the part I couldn't stop thinking about."

QUESTION 4 · WHY THIS COMPANY?

21 rounds

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "Why do you want to join Acko?" (Acko) · "Why Affinity Global? ... What makes you a better fit vs. others?" (Affinity Global) · "Values of Atlassian and which one value will you pick?" (Atlassian)

What they're checking. Whether you've used their product and have a view on it, and the unspoken part: why you, over the forty others who also read the website. Praise alone doesn't answer it. The Acko report put it well: having a dialogue about their strategy, with your own point of view, "goes a long way in showing interest".

① Used it

your own experience

② A view

what they do well

③ A question

what you'd change

④ Fit

why you, over 40 others

FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · MICROSOFT, 2026

Asked "Why Microsoft?", the candidate said they wanted to be at a cutting-edge tech company. The interviewer tested it at once: what interesting technology had they learned about recently? The candidate talked about design patterns for real-time collaborative editing. They couldn't recall the exact algorithms, and the report says "that wasn't a problem". The interviewer then asked them to design a collaborative text editor. Any general reason you give for joining will be tested, so have something real behind it. *ISB BTC Handbook 2026, p. 101. Summarised.*

At Practo, another candidate brought a short, unasked-for document on the company: its user groups, their pain points, what they liked and disliked about the product, and a rough wireframe. The interviewer asked them to send it over. *p. 108.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · fresher, for a PM role at PhonePe

A I've used PhonePe for five years, and I've watched my father's hardware shop in Nagpur move from cash to the PhonePe speaker on the counter. You've won payments: about 46% of UPI transactions in August 2026. But UPI earns almost nothing per payment, so the next few years are about what you build on top, like merchant loans and the devices on the counter. Closing Pincode in December 2025 told me you're choosing where to focus. That's the part I want to work on: turning a shop's payment history into a loan it can trust. I've seen the other side of that from my father, who was turned down by two banks because his sales were "on the phone".

Q What would you change in the merchant app?

A I'd show a shopkeeper why their loan offer is the size it is, and what would raise it. My father ignores offers he doesn't understand.

Why this move: a real personal link, one sourced fact, a view on their strategy and one concrete idea. It is also specific enough that no other candidate could say it.

Facts: UPI share from NPCI data (Aug 2026, via Inc42); Pincode closure (TechCrunch, 5 Dec 2025). Check such facts again on the day; they date quickly.

QUESTION 5 · HOW DO YOU PRIORITISE? A TIME YOU SAID NO

19 rounds

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "A time you didn't build a feature despite planning to, what made you stop, how did you communicate it" (Ethos) · "Example of a time you gave up short-term gains for long-term value" (Ethos) · "How would you prioritise features ... how would you present a case to senior leadership" (2026 report, p. 78)

What they're checking. Whether you compare options against a goal, instead of doing whatever the loudest person asks. And whether you can say no without making an enemy. Put the requests on value against effort (Figure F.7), then explain the one you turned down.



Figure F.7 · Five requests, one sprint. The OTP fix is high value and cheap; the sales head's custom report is costly and helps one person. Saying no to it is the story. *Illustrative example written for this guide.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · summer intern, product team at a lending app

A In my internship I had one engineer for three weeks and five requests. The team's goal that quarter was completed loan applications. I found that 3% of sign-ups on Jio numbers never got their OTP, so fixing that was first: small effort, and every one of those users was lost at the door. The sales head wanted a custom weekly report, which would have taken two of the three weeks and helped one team.

Q How did you tell the sales head no?

A I met him with the numbers, not over chat. I showed what the OTP fix would add in applications, and offered a version of his report from our existing dashboard in two days, with 80% of what he needed. He took it. The OTP fix brought failed sign-ups on Jio down to under 1%.

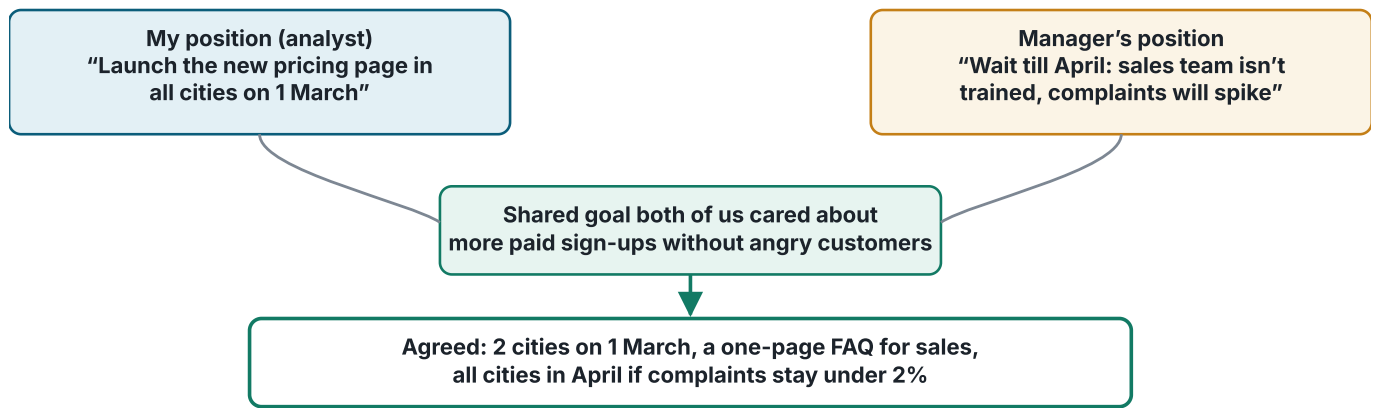
Why this move: a "no" with a reason tied to the shared goal, plus a cheaper option, is what makes it a yes to something else.

QUESTION 6 · A CONFLICT OR DISAGREEMENT

13 rounds

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "tell me about a time when you disagreed with your manager, both an example where I was right and one where my manager was right" (Ethos) · "Strengths? Weaknesses? Conflict in the past?" (Cashfree) · "How do you deal with folks disagreeing with you?" (2026 report, p. 108)

What they're checking. Whether you can disagree without making it personal, and whether you can lose an argument gracefully. The Ethos version is clever: it asks for one you won and one you lost. Prepare both. The move that works in almost every conflict story is to step back from the two positions to the goal both sides share, then find a small test that settles the worry (Figure F.8).



Step back from the two positions to the goal you share, then find a test that answers the worry. Illustrative example.

Figure F.8 · From two positions to one plan. Each side wanted something reasonable. The agreed plan tests the manager's worry instead of arguing about it. *Illustrative example written for this guide.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · pricing analyst at an edtech company

A I'd built a simpler pricing page and wanted it live in all cities on 1 March, before admissions season. My manager wanted to wait till April, because the sales team hadn't been trained on the new plans and she expected complaints. We went back and forth twice. Then I asked what we both wanted, and it was the same thing: more paid sign-ups without angry parents. So I suggested two cities on 1 March, a one-page FAQ for sales, and all cities in April if complaints stayed under 2%.

Q And? Were you right?

A Partly. Sign-ups in the two cities rose 11%. But complaints hit 3% in the first week, on one plan name that confused people, so she was right about that. We renamed it, and it went national in April. I'd still push for the early test. I'd also have shown the plan names to three salespeople first.

Why this move: admitting the manager was partly right makes the story believable, and covers the "one where your manager was right" half of the question.

Weak line

"She just didn't understand the data, so I escalated to her boss."

Better line

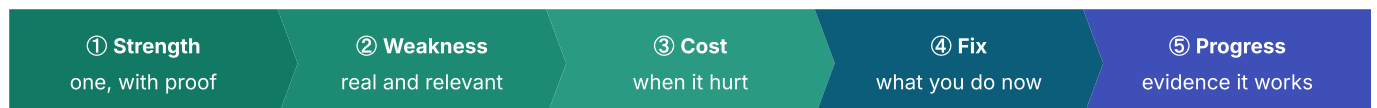
"We were arguing about dates. Once we agreed the goal, the test we ran settled it."

QUESTION 7 · STRENGTHS AND WEAKNESSES

12 rounds, often in HR and founder rounds

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "quality you would hate seeing in your teammates" (Paytm) · "What is your superpower? How much would you rate yourself on hard work?" (Winzo, founder round) · "weaknesses and what I am doing to improve them" (a CXO stress round, p. 81) · "What are your weaknesses that can obstruct your performance as a Product Manager?" (p. 162)

What they're checking. Self-awareness. A strength with no proof sounds like a claim. A weakness that is really a strength ("I work too hard") tells them you won't admit anything, which is itself a weakness. Pick a real one that matters in a PM job but won't sink you, show when it cost you, and what you now do about it.



EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · fresher, engineering graduate with one internship

A My strength is turning a messy problem into one clear page. In my internship, five teams had different numbers for the same funnel; I wrote a one-page definition of each step that all five signed off, and it's still in use. My weakness is that I hold on to work too long before showing it. In the same internship I spent a week polishing an analysis that my manager redirected in ten minutes. Now I share a rough draft by day two, even if it looks unfinished. In my last three projects I got the key correction in the first week instead of the last.

Q Name one quality you'd hate in a teammate.

A Saying "done" when it isn't. I can plan around a delay I know about. I can't plan around one I find out about on launch day.

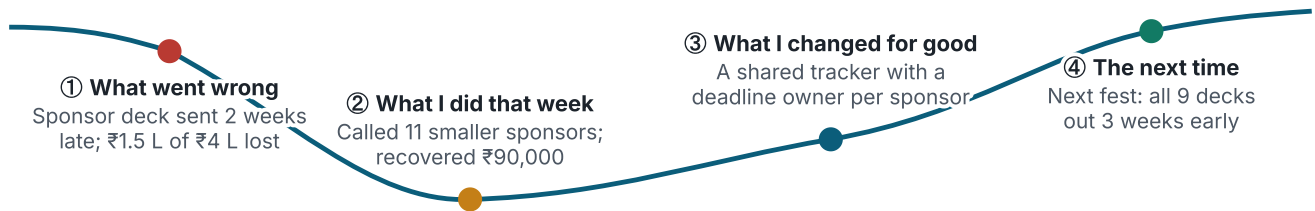
Why this move: the Paytm question is the weakness question turned around. Answer with a behaviour, not a personality type, and give the reason in one line.

QUESTION 8 · A FAILURE, OR A TIME YOU WERE CRITICISED

named in 5 rounds; the least-prepared story

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "What was some time when you were criticized?" · "As a team, give an instance when you failed" · "Did you criticize anyone and were you criticised by anyone?" (Atlassian) · "Do you follow the do it right first-time approach or fail fast approach?" (Dream11)

What they're checking. Whether you own your part, and whether anything changed afterwards. The usual weak answer fails on both: all "we", and it ends at "it all worked out". A good failure story is a curve (Figure F.9): it goes down, you act, and it comes back up because you changed how you work, with proof from the next time.



Most weak answers stop at ①, or jump from ① to "it all worked out". Points ③ and ④ are what the interviewer is scoring. Illustrative.

Figure F.9 · The recovery arc. What went wrong, what you did that week, what you changed for good, and the proof that the change worked. *A college-fest story; illustrative.*

FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · MASTERCARD, 2026

A candidate mentioned a startup on their resume. The interviewer asked: if you turned down every offer and started again, what would you do? The candidate listed steps any textbook would give: market research, demand estimation, finding white space, the problem to solve. The report says the interviewer "wasn't very impressed", and the interview ended there. A question about your own past venture wants *your* lessons: what you got wrong the first time and what you'd do differently, not a general method. *ISB BTC Handbook 2026, p. 118. Summarised.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · fresher, college-fest sponsorship

A I led sponsorship for our college fest, with a ₹4 lakh target. I was late sending our deck to our biggest sponsor, by two weeks, because I kept improving it. By the time it arrived, their budget had gone to another college. That cost us ₹1.5 lakh. That week I called 11 smaller local sponsors and brought back ₹90,000, so we ended at about 85% of target. The lasting fix was a shared tracker with a deadline and one owner for every sponsor, and a rule that a deck goes out when it's good enough, not perfect. The next year, as a mentor, I saw all nine decks go out three weeks early.

Q So do you do it right first time, or fail fast?

A It depends on the cost of being wrong. A sponsor deck, fail fast and fix. A payment flow that moves people's money, get it right first.

Why this move: "it depends" is only a good answer if you say on what. The cost of a mistake decides it.

QUESTION 9 · LEADING OR PERSUADING WITHOUT AUTHORITY

8 rounds, plus many "convince" follow-ups

AS ACTUALLY ASKED "If you have to convince your founder to prioritise this solution, how ... Now, you have to convince your CFO to give money for it" (Salesforce) · "the candidate had to convince an engineer to take on a project" (p. 143) · "leadership skills, evidence of proactiveness" (a hiring-manager round, p. 82)

What they're checking. A PM has almost no one reporting to them, so all their work is persuasion. They want to see that you understood what the other person cared about and made it easy for them to say yes.



FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · SALESFORCE, 2026

After the candidate argued for a solution, the interviewer asked how they would convince the founder, then the CFO. The candidate kept the same reasoning for the CFO because they still thought it held, and said so. A third follow-up then changed the conditions (low barriers to entry, competitors you can't beat), and the candidate changed their plan to match. Keeping your view when only the audience changes, and updating it when the facts change, is the skill being tested. *ISB BTC Handbook 2026, p. 113. Summarised.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · business role, the stock-tracker story

A I needed 30 depot managers, none of whom reported to me, to fill in a new stock tracker every day. Their first reaction was “one more report”. So I visited six depots and asked what they hated about month-end. The answer was the calls from sales asking “do you have stock?”. I added a view that sales could check themselves, which cut those calls, and I took one old daily form off their plate. I started with the two depot managers others listened to. After their pilot they told the rest at the monthly review, which worked better than anything I could have said. 28 of 30 were using it within eight weeks.

Why this move: you persuade by removing work and giving people something they want, and you let respected peers carry the message.

QUESTION 10 · WHERE DO YOU SEE YOURSELF IN FIVE YEARS?

7 rounds

AS ACTUALLY ASKED “why PM, why Flipkart, where do you see yourself in 5 years” (Flipkart) · “What’s your goal in next 5 years” (Housing.com) · “What are your long-term aspirations, and how does joining Affinity play a part in that?” (Affinity Global)

What they’re checking. Whether this job is a real step for you or a stopgap, and whether you’ll stay. Name the skill you want to build first, the scope you want later, and how this job connects the two. Avoid titles (“I want to be a VP”) and avoid anything that sounds like leaving (“start my own company in two years”).

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · any background

A For the first two years, I want to get very good at the basics: shipping small things fast, and learning to read the data on what they did. In five years I’d like to own a whole product area, say the seller side of a marketplace, where I decide the roadmap and answer for its numbers. This role is the right start if new PMs here ship to real users early, as your team described at the pre-placement talk. Shipping and then reading the results is the fastest way I know to learn. *(Say this only if it’s true of that company.)*

QUESTION 11 · HOW DO YOU USE AI IN YOUR WORK?

16 rounds, new this year

AS ACTUALLY ASKED “How do you use vibe coding tools like Replit/Lovable in your daily life?” · “Which is your favorite AI product? Why?” (Affinity Global) · “how I use AI in day-to-day” (a hiring-manager round, p. 82)

What they’re checking. Whether you actually use these tools and know where they go wrong. Name two or three specific habits, one thing you built or saved, and one limit you’ve hit. If it’s on your resume, expect to show it.

FROM A REAL INTERVIEW · HILABS, 2026

Before defending their case deck, one candidate asked ChatGPT to generate more questions an interviewer might ask about it, and prepared answers. In the round, they also kept naming the risk and the fix for everything they proposed. The interviewer praised the discussion at the end. *ISB BTC Handbook 2026, p. 83. Summarised.*

EXAMPLE ANSWER (WRITTEN FOR THIS GUIDE) · MBA student

A Three ways. I paste in app-store reviews and ask for the main complaints, then I read 20 of the reviews myself to check it hasn’t made any up. I built a small prototype of a budget tracker on Lovable in an evening to test an idea with five friends before writing anything down. And I use it to argue against my own case answers. The limit I hit: for Indian market numbers it will confidently give figures with no source, so I never use one without checking it.

BEHAVIOURAL INTERVIEWS · DELIVERY

Stress rounds, curveballs and the last five minutes

When the interviewer pushes on purpose

Some rounds are built to rattle you. The 2026 reports describe several:

- **Mastercard:** asked for a favourite data product, then a second favourite, then a third, before finally settling on one (Datadog) and discussing it.
- **A CXO round:** described as “a stress test, much like a B-school interview”, with questions on weaknesses and what the candidate was doing about them.
- **Cashfree:** the CPO asked about non-work passion projects and how the candidate would measure their success, where there’s no framework to lean on.
- **Amadeus:** the interviewer “drilled down on each line of my answer” and “tested the confidence in my answer”.

The pushback is usually the format, not a sign you’re failing. Stay calm, and keep your story the same. If they keep drilling the same point, they’re checking that the story holds when it’s repeated, not waiting for a better version. Inventing a better version under pressure is the one sure way to lose, because the next question will find the gap.

Curveball	What to do
“I don’t have an example of that”	Don’t invent one. Say “the closest I have is…” and tell a real, nearby story; or say what you would do and why, and label it as hypothetical.
You forget a number	Say you don’t recall it exactly and give the direction and size you’re sure of (the Practo candidate’s CAC answer).
“That doesn’t sound right”	Ask what part doesn’t fit, answer that part, and keep your version unless they give you a new fact.
They jump to a product question	Treat it as a small case: two or three clarifying questions, then structure. Your story bank and your case practice are the same muscle.
Values questions (“pick one of our values”)	Read the values before the day. Pick one, and back it with a real story, not an adjective.

How long to talk

Too short	A bit short	About right	Getting long	Rambling
thin; they must drag it out	fine for a follow-up	90 s to 2½ min, then stop and let them ask	cut the situation	they stop listening and plan to interrupt
0 min	1 min	2 min	3 min	4 min
			5 min	

Figure F.10 • Answer length. Aim for 90 seconds to two and a half minutes on a story, then stop and let them choose where to go. A short answer is easy to extend; a long one can’t be taken back. *Author’s guide; the two-minute mark follows the ISB handbook’s advice (p. 40).*

The questions you ask at the end

Worth asking

- ✓ “What does a new PM on your team ship in the first three months?”
- ✓ “What’s one decision your team argued about recently, and how did you settle it?”
- ✓ A question that comes from your own research, such as “You closed X last year. What did the team learn from it?”

Better avoided

- ✗ Anything on the careers page (“What does your company do?”)
- ✗ Pay, leave or work-from-home rules, in a first-round interview
- ✗ “How did I do?”, which puts the interviewer on the spot

Connect the dots

The habits from case interviews carry straight over. Clarifying the question becomes “do you want a time I was right or a time I was wrong?”. Giving numbers becomes “calls fell from 9,000 to 7,400”. Naming the trade-off becomes “we lost agent detail, so we kept it on their screen”. And the stronger answers throughout are built the same way as a good case answer: a clear goal, a few steps with reasons, a result you can check, and what you’d do next.

KEY IDEA • THE WEAK FEST ANSWER, FIXED IN FOUR LINES

“I led fest sponsorship with a ₹4 lakh target, and I sent our biggest sponsor’s deck two weeks late because I kept polishing it. We lost ₹1.5 lakh. That week I called 11 local sponsors and got back ₹90,000. Since then I send work when it’s good enough to be useful, not perfect, and track every deadline with an owner. The next year all nine decks went out three weeks early.”

Same story, same facts. The difference is the word “I”, the numbers, and the last two sentences.